He held out for an actor who was a giant. A lot of players don’t look like players when they are out of uniform and, yes, some fellows who aren’t players look like they are when they put on a football uniform.

I remembered a cameraman who had once told me that the people in the front office believed only what they saw on film. I got in my car and drove home as fast as I could and dug into the trunk I had brought from Dixon. I found a yearbook photo of myself in my college football uniform, raced back to the studio, and put it on the producer’s desk.

He studied the picture, looked up at me, and said, “Can I keep this for a while?” I hadn’t been home more than an hour when the phone rang. It was a call telling me to be at the studio at eight in the morning to test for the role of George Gipp.

Pat O’Brien volunteered to play Rockne in my test. The next day, the producer called and said: “Reagan, you’re playing the Gipper.”

A few weeks after we finished filming *Knute Rockne—All American*, I sat in the back row of a small movie theater in Pasadena where Warner Brothers often sneak-previewed its new pictures. Pat was there too, along with a number of studio executives. We were waiting to sample an audience’s reaction to the movie for the first time.

As the picture began to unreel in the dark theater, I sensed a glow radiating from the audience like a warm fire. I was in the picture only a few minutes, but it contained a very emotional scene. Just before Gipp died, I said to Rockne: “Some day when things are tough and the breaks are going against the boys, ask them to go in there and win one for the Gipper. I don’t know where I’ll be but I’ll know about it and I’ll be happy.”

As I spoke these words, men and women in the audience started pulling out their handkerchiefs. Then, from the back